

Rootless wonder

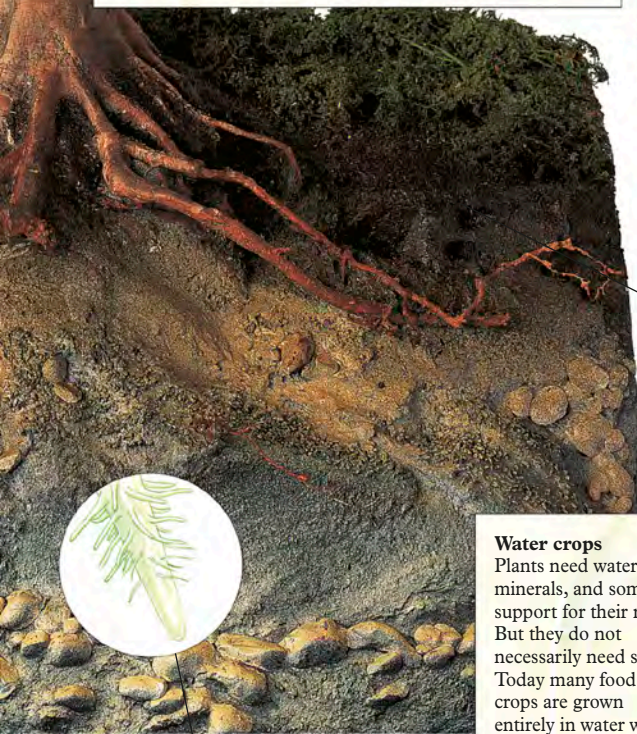
Draped like strange beards over the branches of trees, the extraordinary Spanish moss plant survives with no roots at all. Spanish moss grows in subtropical climates where the air is very wet. It absorbs all the moisture it needs through its fine, threadlike leaves.



Rock climbers

Alpine plants grow against rock faces, to protect themselves from high winds and icy squalls. Their tiny roots wriggle into cracks in the rock.

Most roots grow in the top 12 inches (30 centimeters) of soil. This part contains most of the important minerals the tree needs.



Water crops

Plants need water, minerals, and some support for their roots. But they do not necessarily need soil. Today many food crops are grown entirely in water with special pebbles. They are given liquid minerals to replace those in the soil.



Every root grows a mass of tiny hairs near its tip to absorb water from the soil.

